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Memories of steel

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Times photo by SALLY MAXSON

A small crowd gathers Wednesday after the dedication of the new J&L Historical Society memorial outside the Aliquippa police station recognizing former Jones & Laughlin Steel Corp. and LTV Corp. workers "who made the impossible possible in the production of steel."

ALIQUIPPA — Near a busy intersection on Aliquippa's Franklin Avenue, Jane Delanko addressed a small crowd that gathered Wednesday in front of a black granite monument outside the city's police station.

The J&L Historical Society organized the ceremony dedicating the monument, which recognizes former Jones & Laughlin Steel Corp. and LTV Corp. workers "who made the impossible possible in the production of steel," the memorial reads.

"This was a long time coming," said Delanko, of Hopewell Township, chairwoman of the J&L Historical Society.

By 1950, J&L was the fourth-largest steel producer in the world. In 1967, the company's Aliquippa Works employed 14,000 people. LTV bought the company in 1968.

Dan Britza, a historical society member, said the thousands of workers came from all over the county and beyond.

"People who worked at this plant were from all over this county, West Virginia and Ohio, too," Britza said.

The historical society spent several years working on a memorial marker. Britza said the original plan was to place a giant melting pot near the city's entrance off Route 51. LTV agreed to leave the large pot for the committee to use as a memorial, but Britza said the pot mysteriously disappeared, so the group came up with another plan.

After former chairman Paul Piccirilli passed away several years ago, the group still had money in a bank account, but no memorial. Delanko, 81, is credited with spearheading the project to completion.

“She knew something had to be done,” Britza said.

Rome Monument designed the \$11,000 memorial, with enough money left over to pay for landscaping elements around the site, which was done by Lenny Smith of Classic Lawn Care and Landscaping Inc.

Aliquippa Mayor Anthony Battalini presented Delanko with a proclamation from the city for her work. He said the monument represents all the workers who spent time in the mill, and it should grab people’s attention at the busy end of town where streetscape revitalization has already begun.

Delanko said the original plan was to put the monument by the Beaver County Courthouse, but said she is pleased with the Aliquippa location, because it’s near to where the mills once stood.

Beaver County Commissioners Chairman Tony Amadio remembered working alongside his father and grandfather in the mill to pay his way through college, and before that, growing up as a boy in West Aliquippa, seeing nighttime skies lit red from molten slag at night and black soot covering windows and porches. He said his grandmother swept the soot in the 1930s, then his mother in the 1950s and his wife in the 1970s.

“Now the porches are clean and the paychecks are gone, but the legacy lives on,” Amadio said.

Tom Stoner, city administrator, thanked the group for doing something positive for the city.

“When we go through the (mill) tunnel, it’s just a shame that the jobs aren’t here anymore,” said Stoner, adding that he believes more jobs are on the horizon.

Ron Zuccaro, the last United Steelworkers Local 1211 president, remembered there used to be 72 bars on the avenue during the mill’s heyday and the Woodlawn Southern bus company ran loads of workers into the city. Zuccaro said it’s important to “carry on the tradition for generations to remember what the mills were all about.”

Zorie Miller of Aliquippa, a historical society member, said it’s important to keep labor history alive.

“To know where you’re going, you have to know where you’ve been, and I firmly believe that,” Miller said.